

Ἐπικράτης ὁ κωμικός

Epicrates the Comic on Lais the Courtesan

eul_aid: fka

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic \(com, frg\)](#)
Domain: [Κωμῳδία](#) [Comedy](#)
Format: [Ἑμμετρος](#) [Verse](#)

Epicrates was an Athenian comic poet active in the early 4th century BCE. He worked during a transitional period for Greek comedy, as the style shifted from the politically focused Old Comedy toward the more socially and philosophically satirical Middle Comedy.

Very little is known about his personal life, and some ancient sources confused him with a 5th-century politician of the same name. His plays survive only in fragments. Ancient records attribute several comedies to him, with titles like **Antilais**, **Dolos**, **The Merchant**, **The Revellers**, and **The Chorus**.

A notable fragment from **The Revellers** comically depicts students at Plato's Academy attempting to define a pumpkin through philosophical debate. This piece is considered one of the earliest comic portrayals of Plato's circle.

According to modern scholars, Epicrates is a significant figure for understanding the evolution of Athenian theater. His fragments illustrate the move away from direct political satire toward parody of intellectual life, social manners, and standardized character types. While his complete works are lost, these fragments provide valuable insight into the cultural and intellectual atmosphere of 4th-century Athens.

Works (2)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Λαΐδος τῆς ἐταίρας](#) · [Fragments on Lais the Courtesan](#) · 60 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Λαΐδος τῆς Ἑταίρας](#) · [Fragments on Lais the Hetaira](#) · 65 passages